Enriched with sherry, this slow-cooked soup is a classic for flavorful comfort eating. If you prefer a chunky texture, the soup also tastes good unblended.

oxtail soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 20 MINS, PLUS 1 HR CHILLING **COOK** 4 HRS 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE SHERRY

2 tbsp vegetable oil
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1lb 5oz (600g) oxtails, disjointed, available from your butcher
1 onion, sliced
2 carrots, diced
2 celery ribs, diced
1 x 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
¼ bunch of parsley
1 bay leaf
2 sprigs of fresh thyme
1 tbsp flour
1 tbsp butter
⅔ cup dry sherry

1 Heat the oil in a large saucepan, season the oxtails with salt and pepper, add them to the hot oil, and cook until golden on all sides. Add the onion and cook until softened slightly. Add 2 quarts (2 liters) of water, season with salt and pepper, and simmer, uncovered, for about 2 hours. Cover and continue to simmer for another 2 hours. Check to see if you need more liquid during cooking, and add as needed.

2 Add the carrots, celery, and tomatoes. Tie the parsley, bay leaf, and thyme sprigs together with kitchen string and place in the pan. Bring to a boil and simmer for 30 minutes, or until the vegetables are tender.

3 Remove the herb bundle and discard. Scoop out the meat, remove from the bones, and discard the skin and bones. Strain the stock, reserving the vegetables. Refrigerate the stock for an hour or more. Using a blender, process the meat and vegetables and set aside.

4 Once the stock is chilled, remove the fat from the top and discard. Reheat the stock. In a large, dry frying pan, brown the flour over high heat. Cool slightly. Add the butter and blend. A little at a time, stir in the stock and the meat-vegetable purée. Season with salt and pepper to taste, and add the sherry just before serving.